PETERLOUGHNANCORKGOLFCLUBEDIT

Travel Radio Australia, we're here in Carn at the International Golf Travel Market and I've run into Peter Lochnan from the Cork Golf Club in Ireland. Peter, welcome to the program. Hi Geoff, thanks for having me.

Now Peter, I have a very soft spot for Cork because my father was a Cork man born and bred there and was in the Irish Navy and before he moved to Dublin to meet my mum but it's a beautiful part of Ireland and right on the south coast. Your golf club is virtually accessible from the city centre which is pretty amazing. Yes, we're 10 minutes drive from the city centre so it's quite unique when you think of golf courses.

A lot of them are maybe a bit a little bit more remote or can be a little bit further away from big centres of population but we're right in Cork Harbour, about 10 minutes from the city so yeah it's lovely. It's very accessible to the city so people can stay in the city and either even get the train out to Cork Golf Club, it's that handy. And what is your background in golf? Were you a player before or how did that work? No, I'm possibly the worst golfer in the golf business.

No, I came from the hotel business so I very much came from the luxury hotel scene in Cork and I used to run Ballymilloo House which is a really nice country house, five-star hotel near Cork City and other properties. I grew up in a hotel and my parents had a hotel up the country and awfully so I was always a hotelier and when I saw that the opportunity to join the golf industry just felt like a dream job to combine that hospitality, develop the member and visitor experience in the club, ensure the food and beverage was up to a really high level and all of that, all that welcomed that hospitality that Ireland is ultimately famous for I suppose is what I suppose was seen in me as being the things I could bring to Cork Golf Club. And tell us about the golf club itself, I suppose you have historical buildings and all sorts of things going on there.

Cork Golf Club was founded in 1888 so it's one of the top ten in terms of age in the country but what's unique about Cork is it moved, the club was located elsewhere in Cork but it moved in about 1905. There was an old quarry on the side of the river and a lot of the stone that was taken from the quarry was brought to build kind of large buildings and estates and all over Ireland and the UK and once the quarry was emptied and finished it became an ideal location then for a golf course because of which it's very free draining, it's on the harbour so the setting is stunning but then in 1924 the Golf Committee at the time enlisted a reasonably well-known architect at the time, Alistair McKenzie who went on to obviously design Augusta and Cypress Point and Royal Melbourne and all these places. So Alistair McKenzie redesigned Cork Golf Club between 1924 and 1925 and the McKenzie design now is still the course we play today so that's what really excites people when they come to Cork.

It's a really lovely addition to Old Head for example if you're in the area but we host big events, we hosted the Irish Open back in 1932 for example. This year we host the Irish Amateur

Championship, or 2007 at least. The last time we hosted it, Shane Lowry won it in 2007 so it's a lovely 20-year anniversary remembering that's a player who's gone on to such great lengths in the game and it put it to members club.

At the end of it all we're a members club so it's a really accessible golf course. We have some members in their 90s who play a couple of times a week down to kids in their seven and eight ten years of age so it's very playable for all ages and it's a really wonderful members club at the end of the day but we love visitors as well. And are you a Cork man yourself originally? I'm from sort of visited Offaly but Offaly would be famous for places like Clann Macnoy's where on the River Shannon the oldest monastic site in the country and places like Tullamore, Dew, Whiskey and Burgh Castle is where I'm from so yeah it's a but Ireland is such a small country it's I can visit my mum and dad in a couple of hours.

Now Cork itself you must know it pretty well having you know working at the Cork Golf Club and it's such a great city because it's such a magnificent friendly vibe they're going on. Well you mentioned for example your dad the Navy that the center of the Irish Navy is in Cork and it's a real maritime heritage town as such the River Lee splits the city and it's a beautiful setting on the river very close to beaches and the seaside and all that kind of stuff but still with the kind of facilities now and the sophistication of a modern European capital you have beautiful features in Cork City you've got obviously the people I honestly that's why people are coming to Ireland for the most part that's what kind of separates Ireland from other destinations not to speak of any other country but just the welcome in Ireland is phenomenal but some of the things you'd have in Cork like the Middleton Whiskey distillery for example about 15 minutes up from us in the Golf Club where all the jemisin in Ireland is distilled all the red breasts all the the green spot all those really famous paddy powers Irish whiskeys are all distilled in Middleton the visitor center there is superb and a lot of our visitors golf visitors will go there the city itself you just got great pubs and restaurants you've got thing it's a university city so you've got lovely concerts and events and theaters and you know so you little bit more to offer your visitor than than some of the smaller destinations which would be kind of more well known for the golf yeah and tell us a two or three of your sort of offbeat must-see things if someone's coming into Cork for the first time and you know something that you would highly recommend as a local if it were me know that and especially when you're when you're welcoming golfers the sport kind of unites everybody I believe and in Ireland we have hurling and Gaelic football and there are sports they're really only played in Ireland and among the diaspora so I would go to a hurling match at any opportunity I would go to a hurling match and Cork is kind of the center of hurling so traditionally Cork would be one of the superpowers in hurling along with Tipperary and Kilkenny so it's very parochial it's very passionate and even at any level or age grade I'd love a visitor to Cork to see a hurling match last Sunday we had the county final for example and it's a big day out villages playing against one another and so on so that I'd love to do something like that if I had visitors coming over I'd bring them to something like that the English market is a great one like when the Queen visited Ireland in 2011 she visited the English market and just I suppose that the heritage in the history of the

English market is it's a working market you've got lovely little shops stall holders everything from selling offal and tripe and rasheen and all these traditional Irish foods all the way up to kind of olives and fancy teas and all that kind of stuff but the English market is a must-see but you've also got some of the theatres like the Cork Opera House is phenomenal we have the Guinness Jazz Festival taking place you've bands like Boney M for example are playing in Cork Opera House this weekend you know we all know Boney M and I don't know if the lineup is still the same but they'll be playing so like I'd always try and take in something cultural and there's so many wonderful plays and shows and art galleries and so on so and tell us about the transport in the town it's pretty good it's easy to get around Cork I know we're very lucky I live in Middleton for example and I can get the train into the city centre there's great transport there's bus and train services all over the city so we're very just because you're a city we're a little bit more opportunity to maybe fly in and not have to worry about driving on the wrong side of the road until you're leaving Cork you know you can maybe handle the public transport in the first instance but even getting in a cab with an Irish taxi driver is a bit of fun too so don't overlook that they'd be your best friend after about five minutes I think you know especially if you listen to them exactly and from Cork as well just on the southwest coast you've got County Kerry you've got Kalani all these beautiful places that you can get to really easily to the coast right sure oh yeah and and West Cork is also a really special place that did the only problem with West Cork is that they don't have after the old head of conceal there is no marquee golf course down in West Cork on a lynx that people will play so a lot of visitors will would love West Cork and you've got the real history of West Cork people will know about Michael Collins and even on the road from Cork to Killarney a five-minute detour will take you to the ambush site where Michael Collins was killed in August 1922 in the Civil War you know and that kind of heritage coming alive is beautiful for visitors when they come but yes a lot of our guests will having left Cork will go on to Killarney people see Killarney I suppose essentially from a golf point of view anyway as almost a capital of Irish golf and nearly the capital of Irish tourism and there's a great range of hotels you've got some lovely golf courses obviously that you can hit from Killarney like Duke's, Waterville, Dingle, Ballybunyan, Treli, they're on every golfers bucket list so it's a really positive it's a really big proper destination from there Peter Lochnan it's been fabulous speaking to you and can you tell us how people can find out more about Cork Golf Club online yes Cork Golf Club.ie Jeff is our website and everything comes through that so any any inquiries or info at Cork Golf Club.ie you will get us but you'll find us but we love nothing better better as Irish people get on the phone and have a chat and we'll even with the time difference we'll we'll make sure you get over and enjoy your trip to Cork whenever you get the chance. Do you speak any Gaelic yourself? I speak a little bit of Irish so my children have to still very much learn it in school so I tried to help them with their homework just to keep myself connected with the language.

Well thank you very much Dias Merigat in Irish and thank you so much for being on Travel Radio Australia. Thank you Dias Merigat is padrig.